Enter the environs of Imtiaz Ali's Window Seat Films in Versova, a residential suburb in Mumbai known for being home to as many film offices as cafés, and one cannot miss glimpses of Punjabi artist Amar Singh Chamkila, heralded as the 'Elvis Presley of Punjab'. Notable is a pin board that holds photographs and clippings of Chamkila and his second wife, Amarjot, an equally talented vocalist. At the peak of their career, which coincided with the rise of insurgency in the state, the duo was shot dead in 1988 in Mehsampur in Jalandhar district. On April 12, an Ali-directed biopic on the highs and lows of the duo, played by Diljit Dosanjh and Parineeti Chopra, will release on Netflix.

Chamkila, for Ali, is a "universal story", for not only was he a leading representative of globally popular Punjabi music who inspired a generation of artists but also because he's the rare Indian member of "the infamous 27 Club". It includes popular artists like Jimi Hendrix, Jim Morrison, Janis Joplin, Kurt Cobain and Amy Winehouse, all of whom passed away at that age. Says Ali, "It happens everywhere in the world. Many musicians in America lost their lives to violence. Chamkila too had crazy popularity. It was a dramatic life and time [in Punjab]."

That's only part of the reason why Ali wanted to make a film on Chamkila. Best known for songs—many of them ribald—that struck a chord with the masses, Chamkila was also a fascinating figure, one whose life was filled with intrigue, complexities and some controversy. That he had humble village origins and sang about relatable issues—more so at a time when his homeland was marred with conflict—elevated his status as the hero who offered a balm with his songs. "His intention was not to change the world. He was a humble servant who was serving the dish that the audience wanted to eat," says Ali of him. "He was naughty in the same way people are in villages, only he did it in an artful way. He has not criticised any political entity [in his songs]. All his songs were about celebration and making people have fun."

There is a deeper discussion, Ali hopes, *Chamkila* generates on the moral compass that people increasingly apply to creative works. Chamkila's verses touched on village life, extra-marital affairs, desire, alcoholism and masculinity. "Who should decide what is right and wrong?" asks Ali, citing the film *Animal*, which generated a lot of criticism even as it set the box office ablaze. "What is the life of an artist in that situation? What does he go through?" Helping Ali get a grip on Chamkila were some of his closest collaborators, which included his band members and sound recordist as well as his family members.

Ali is all too aware that his 'fanboys' are like-

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Diljit Dosanjh and Parineeti Chopra in a still from *Chamkila*